

■ Step-by-Step Guide: Feeding Fermented Feed to Chickens

■ What Is Fermented Feed?

Fermenting feed involves soaking it in water to allow beneficial bacteria to grow. This pre-digests the grains, improves nutrient bioavailability, and makes the feed easier to digest.

■ Supplies Needed:

- 1 Non-metal container (bucket, large jar, or food-grade tub)
- 2 Clean water (non-chlorinated or dechlorinated)
- 3 Stirring utensil
- 4 Lid (loose-fitting or breathable cover)
- 5 Dry chicken feed (whole grains, pellets, or crumble)

■ Step 1: Choose Your Feed

- 1 You can ferment:
 - 2 - Layer or grower pellets/crumble
 - 3 - Scratch grains
 - 4 - Whole grains (e.g. wheat, oats, barley)
 - 5 - Mixed rations
- 6 Avoid feeds with added medication (like medicated chick starter), as fermentation may reduce effectiveness.

■ Step 2: Mix Feed and Water

- 1 Add dry feed to your container (start with enough for 1–3 days).
- 2 Add water until the feed is fully submerged, about 1–2 inches above the feed line.
- 3 Stir thoroughly to remove air pockets and ensure even moisture.

■ Step 3: Ferment for 2–3 Days

- 1 Cover loosely (e.g., with a cloth, paper towel, or lid not sealed airtight).
- 2 Let it sit at room temperature, out of direct sunlight.
- 3 Stir once or twice daily.
- 4 The mixture should begin to bubble slightly and smell mildly sour or yeasty—like sourdough or yogurt.
- 5 Ready-to-feed fermentation time is 2–3 days, depending on temperature. Warmer = faster.

■■ Step 4: Feed Your Chickens

- 1 Scoop out the top portion of the fermented feed.
- 2 Drain excess water (optional) and serve in a clean dish or trough.
- 3 Only give what they'll eat in 30–45 minutes to avoid spoilage.

■ Step 5: Maintain the Ferment

- 1 Top off with more feed and water after each scoop to keep the culture going.
- 2 Clean out and restart the batch every 1–2 weeks to prevent buildup or contamination.

❄️ ■ Optional: Cold Weather Tip

- 1 In cold climates, ferment indoors or in a sheltered area to maintain activity.
- 2 Feed warm (not hot) water can be used for mixing in winter.

■ Tips for Success

- 1 Use non-chlorinated water to protect the beneficial microbes (let tap water sit 24 hours if needed).
- 2 If it smells rotten or moldy, discard and start fresh.
- 3 Gradually introduce fermented feed over a few days to avoid digestive upset.